SAMPLE

Qawm Yasin: The City of the Believers

The Story of the City of Yasin (يس) in the Quran

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Introduction: The City That Refused the Messengers

The Quran tells of a city that received messengers from Allah and rejected them. The city is not named. The messengers are not named. The story is told in Surah Yasin (36:13-29), and it is told with a brevity and a power that compress the entire drama of prophethood and rejection into seventeen verses. "And We sent to them two, but they denied them, so We reinforced them with a third, and they said: Indeed, we are messengers to you" (36:14).

The story of the city of Yasin is the story of every city that has received the truth and turned away. It is the story of the messengers who come with the message, the people who refuse the message, the one believer who speaks for the message, the warning that the messengers bring, the destruction that the refusal provokes, the regret that the destruction produces, the parable that the story becomes, and the resurrection that the story illustrates.

This book -- the thirteenth in the Nations and Peoples of the Quran sub-series -- explores the story of the city of Yasin as the Quran tells it. It examines the surah itself, the three messengers who were sent, the rejection of the people, the one believer who spoke from the edge of the city, the warning of the garden and the night visit, the destruction by the single cry, the regret of the destroyed, the parable of the garden, and the resurrection that the dead land reveals.

The Quran's treatment of this story reveals a pattern that runs through every prophetic narrative: the pattern of the message and the refusal, the pattern of the messenger and the rejection, the pattern of the one who believes among the many who deny, and the pattern of the destruction that follows the denial. The story is told without names, without location, without historical detail -- because the story is not about a specific city but about every city, not about a specific people but about every people, and not about a specific time but about every time.

The first chapter begins with the surah itself -- the verses of Yasin and what they reveal about the city and its story.

Chapter 1: The Surah -- Yasin and the Story of the City

Surah Yasin is the 36th surah of the Quran, consisting of 83 verses. It is named after the two Arabic letters "Ya Sin" that open the surah -- letters whose meaning is known to Allah, and which the tradition interprets in various ways, including as an address to the Prophet Muhammad or as a name for the surah itself. The surah is often called "the heart of the Quran" in the tradition, a description that reflects its central themes of prophethood, resurrection, and divine oneness.

The story of the city appears in verses 13-29 of the surah. These seventeen verses contain the entire narrative: the sending of the messengers, the rejection, the reinforcement with a third messenger, the speech of the believing man, the threat of the people, the single cry of destruction, and the regret of the destroyed. The brevity is the power. The Quran tells the story in seventeen verses and delivers the entire lesson -- the lesson of the message, the refusal, the belief, and the destruction.

The Quran says: "And set forth to them the parable of the people of the city, when the messengers came to it" (36:13). The city is unnamed. The messengers are unnamed. The people are unnamed. The story is presented as a parable -- a mathal -- a story that is told not for its historical detail but for its moral lesson. The city could be any city. The messengers could be any messengers. The people could be any people. The parable is universal -- the universal story of the message and the refusal.

The setting is the city. The city is the place of the people, the place of the power, the place of the wealth. The city is the civilization -- the organized, the structured, the established. The messengers come to the city because the city is where the people are. The messengers come to the civilization because the civilization is where the message is needed. The city is the target -- the target of the message, the target of the warning, the target of the call.

The Quran does not name the city. The tradition offers various identifications -- Antioch, according to some; another city, according to others -- but the Quran itself is silent on the name. The silence is the universality. If the city were named, the story would be about that city. If the city were unnamed, the story would be about every city. The Quran chooses the unnamed -- the unnamed city, the unnamed messengers, the unnamed people -- so that the story belongs to every reader, every generation, every place.

The unnamed city is the lesson -- the lesson that the story is not about a specific time but about all time, not about a specific place but about all places, not about a specific people but about all peoples. The unnamed city is the mirror -- the mirror that every reader holds up to their own city, their own time, their own people. The mirror asks: would we accept the messengers, or would we reject them? Would we believe, or would we deny? Would we be the believing man who spoke from the edge of the city, or would we be the people who threatened the messengers?

The story of the city appears in the context of a surah that is about resurrection and revelation. The surah opens with the oath on the Quran and the confirmation of the prophethood: "By the wise Quran. Indeed, you are of the messengers, on a straight path" (36:2-4). The surah then addresses the denial of the Meccans, describes the signs of Allah in the creation, tells the story of the city, presents the parable of the garden, describes the resurrection with the dead land and the living God, and closes with the sovereignty of Allah and the command to the Prophet.

The context is the message -- the message that the surah delivers through its stories, its signs, and its arguments. The story of the city is one part of the message -- the part that warns the deniers, the part that shows the fate of the rejecters, the part that illustrates the consequence of the refusal. The story is the warning -- the warning that the Meccans and every reader should heed: the city that refused the messengers was destroyed, and the people who deny the message will face the same fate.

The purpose of the story is the lesson. The lesson is: the messengers come, the people refuse, the one believes, the destruction comes, the regret follows. The lesson is the pattern -- the pattern of the prophethood and the rejection, the pattern of the belief and the denial, the pattern of the destruction and the regret. The purpose is the warning -- the warning to the Meccans who were rejecting the Prophet, the warning to every people who reject the message, the warning that the refusal has a consequence and the denial has an end.

The purpose is also the encouragement -- the encouragement of the Prophet who was facing the rejection, the encouragement that he is not alone, the encouragement that the messengers before him were also rejected, and the encouragement that the one who believes among the many is the one who is honored. The purpose is the comfort -- the comfort that the message will prevail, the comfort that the rejection will end, the comfort that the destruction of the deniers and the salvation of the believers is the pattern that the story confirms.

The story has a clear structure. It begins with the sending: "when the messengers came to it" (36:13). It continues with the rejection: "they denied them" (36:14). It introduces the reinforcement: "so We reinforced them with a third" (36:14). It presents the messengers' claim: "Indeed, we are messengers to you" (36:14). It describes the people's accusation: "You are only human beings like us" (36:15). It presents the messengers' response: "Our Lord knows that we are messengers to you" (36:16). It introduces the believing man: "And there came from the farthest part of the city a man, running" (36:20). It delivers the believing man's message: "O my people, follow the messengers" (36:20). It describes the destruction: "It was not but one shout, and immediately they were extinguished" (36:29). And it presents the regret: "If only our people had known" (36:26).

The structure is the arc -- the arc of the prophethood, the rejection, the belief, the destruction, and the regret. The arc is the pattern -- the pattern that the Quran repeats in story after story, the pattern that the surah delivers in seventeen verses, the pattern that is the lesson of the city of Yasin.

The surah is called "the heart of the Quran." The story of the city is the heart of the surah. The heart of the Quran is the story of the messengers and the believers, the story of the message and the refusal, the story of the belief and the destruction. The heart is the core -- the core of the message, the core of the warning, the core of the comfort. The heart beats with the pattern of the prophethood -- the pattern that the city of Yasin illustrates in seventeen verses, the pattern that is the pulse of the Quran.

The heart of the Quran is the story -- the story that is told again and again, the story of the messengers who come and the people who refuse, the story of the one who believes and the many who deny, the story of the destruction and the regret. The heart of the Quran is the lesson -- the lesson that the city of Yasin delivers, the lesson that the heart of the Quran beats: believe the messengers, follow the believers, and do not be among the ones who refuse and are destroyed.
